evil, community, justice and kingdom) is a revelation of the Tamil polity. The Sangam literary works have been grouped into eight anthologies (*Ettuthogai*): (1) *Natrinai*, (2) *Kurunthogai*, (3) *Aingurunooru*, (4) *Paditruppattru*, (5) *Paripadal*, (6) *Kalitthogai*, (7)*Agananooru*, and (8) *Purananooru*; and there is a ninth group of poems called the *Patthupattu* (Ten Idylls).The early part of the first two books of **Tholkappiyam,** a work on Tamil grammar, belongs to the same period.

The famous post-Sangam literature were known as the pathenen *Kilkkanakku*. Besides the two epics *Silappadikaram* also belong to thin period A little later three more epics were return in addition there were five minor epics. and *Eighteen Minor Works* (*Pathinen kilkkanakku*, which includes the *Thirukkural*) were written during this period. *Prabandha* literature consists of poetry of various forms: *kovai*, in which the verses are arranged according to a particular theme (usually about love), and *kalambakam*, in which the end of one stanza/line formed the beginning of the next (usually about kings and bravery) and *parani*. The best illustrations of this tradition are the *Pantikkovai*, *Nandikkalambakam*, and *Kalingattup-parani*.

The ancient Tamil literature of Sangam age, *Thirukkural, Silapathikaram, Manimegalai* etc provide deep insights into the nature of polity, society and culture. Tamil language formed the core and essence of Tamil identity, culture, customs and traditions. Despite the diversity of land, geography, rulers and chieftains spread across the Tamil speaking areas the idea of Tamil country and confederation of Tamil speaking areas did exist. This literary finding(s) is also substantiated by a stone inscription of Kalinga King Kharavela (BC(BCE) 165), who claims to have destroyed a 'Tamil federation' which existed for 113 years. Similarly such a Tamil federation of kings to fight foreign invasion is also mentioned in '*Agananooru*', a Sangam literature. Hence the idea and prevalence of Tamil nationalism is not simply a consequence of colonialism. The roots of Tamil nationalism are linked to the historical role and significance of Tamil language and culture in defining politics that could be traced even in the Sangam age.

The concept of State and the idea king coincided with the territorial emphasis of polity as the Greek city-state. The classical Tamil country known as *Tamizhagam* covered areas south of Tirupati hills up to the tip of the Cape Comorin (Kanyakumari). The land was traditionally classified according to its nature into five geographical regions (*tinai*): the mountainous region (*kurinji*), the forest areas(*mullai*), fertile plains (*marudam*), coastal region (*neidhal*) and arid region (*palai*).

Tamil speaking areas were divided between the principalities of the Cholas (its capital at Uraiyur), the Pandyas (Madurai as capital), the Cheras in most of present Kongunadu and Kerala and the Pallavas (Kanchipuram as capital). Tamil country included several kingdoms ruled by kings (*vendhar*), major and minor chieftains (*vel/ velir*) who was less powerful than the crowned kings. The Sangam poets sang songs of praise about the *velirs*, especially the Seven Patrons, for their generosity towards the poets. Kapilar and Avvaiyar mention chieftains like, Aay, Pari, Ori, Malayan, Elini, Pegan and Nalli..

The virtues of king did include the ideals of *Just Ruler* with qualities of kindness towards the subjects and bravery in the battlefield



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